side to create conditions to ensure that this takes practical shape in the near term.

While these are all compulsions of immediate politics, it is also worthwhile to consider this relationship from the longer perspective of history. A newer generation in both countries have found a more practical logic for forging ties than the earlier lot of political romantics. The real value of Japan lies in its well-earned reputation as the great modernization leader in Eurasia. Its example and experiences have motivated other countries to follow suit and Japan itself has assisted that process. If it could really bring those energies to bear on India now, then the transformational possibilities truly expand. This has gained greater significance in recent years, because the ability of the West to contribute to this agenda has weakened. India may not be a factor in a Japanese strategic posture, but it could well be a beneficiary. A multipolar Asia will really only come about with the participation of Japan.

In Indian politics, Japan is unique in being a relationship that has always enjoyed the distinction of support across the political spectrum. Forging ahead on this account is, therefore, likely to be the least divisive of foreign policy initiatives. Successive governments at the Centre and most state governments have shown deep interest in exploiting the Japan opening. The foundations of the current relationship were laid in 2000 by the visit to India of Prime Minister Mori. That initiative put behind it the acrimony generated by Japan's reaction to India's 1998 nuclear tests. Once the air was cleared, both sides responded steadily to the logic of cooperation. This has taken various forms in the last two decades, and includes much larger commitments of development assistance in hard and soft infrastructure. Japanese support was a crucial factor in India's recovery during the 1991 balance of payments crisis. Even recently, the impact of the currency swap agreement in 2018 underlines its indispensability as an economic partner.

While the economic content of these ties has expanded, the real change has been in the political warming up between India and Japan. Countries who saw each other some decades ago as alternative models in global affairs now found increasing common ground in changed circumstances. Bilaterally, they have initiated a range of dialogues and mechanisms that facilitate policy convergence. An ability to reach agreements in domains as